

Telecom Customer Queries & Related Policy Reference Guide

A structured reference of common customer service queries in the telecom sector mapped to the applicable operator / regulatory (TRAI) policy.

Contents

1. Billing & Charges
2. Network & Connectivity Issues
3. SIM Card, Number Porting & KYC
4. Plans, Recharges & Refunds
5. Roaming & International Services
6. Complaints, Escalation & Grievance Redressal
7. Disconnection, Termination & Data Privacy

1. Billing & Charges

Q: Why was I charged more than my regular monthly plan amount this cycle?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Excess charges are typically due to out-of-bundle usage (data/calls/SMS beyond the plan limit), applicable taxes, one-time add-on purchases, or a mid-cycle plan change. Operators are required to itemize all charges in the bill. Customers can request a detailed billing statement free of cost and dispute any unrecognized charge within the billing-dispute window (usually 30 days from bill generation) as per TRAI's Telecom Consumer Protection Regulations.

Q: I was billed for a value-added service (VAS) I never subscribed to. What can I do?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Under TRAI regulations, VAS can only be activated with explicit customer consent (SMS/IVR/app confirmation). Unsolicited activation entitles the customer to a full refund of the charged amount and immediate deactivation. Customers should raise a written complaint with the operator's customer care; if unresolved within the stipulated time (usually 7 days), it can be escalated to the Appellate Authority or the Telecom Ombudsman.

Q: Can I get an itemized call/data usage bill instead of a summary bill?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Operators must provide an itemized bill on request, free of charge, showing call duration, destination numbers (partially masked for privacy), data sessions, and SMS counts. Requests can be made via the operator's app, website, or customer care within the retention period defined by the operator (commonly 6-12 months of usage history).

Q: My postpaid bill wasn't generated / I didn't receive it. Am I still liable to pay?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Non-receipt of a bill does not waive payment liability, but the due date is extended proportionately and no late payment charge applies if the delay was due to the operator's fault. Customers can always view/download the bill from the operator's self-care app or portal.

2. Network & Connectivity Issues

Q: I'm facing frequent call drops and poor network coverage in my area. What is the operator's obligation?

APPLICABLE POLICY

As per TRAI's Quality of Service (QoS) norms, operators must maintain a call drop rate below the prescribed benchmark (typically under 2%) and provide compensation credits to affected customers in regions where benchmarks are repeatedly not met. Persistent coverage complaints should be logged with a complaint reference number, which the operator must resolve within a defined SLA (commonly 3 working days for network-related issues).

Q: My mobile data speed is much slower than what was promised in my plan.

APPLICABLE POLICY

Operators must disclose Fair Usage Policy (FUP) terms, including speed throttling thresholds, at the time of plan purchase. If speeds fall below FUP-committed levels without the customer exceeding the data cap, this is treated as a service deficiency and is eligible for a complaint and possible bill credit.

Q: There has been no network signal in my area for several days after a storm/outage.

APPLICABLE POLICY

Operators are required to restore service within a defined restoration timeline for both planned and unplanned outages and must proactively inform affected subscribers via SMS where feasible. Extended outages beyond the SLA can be escalated for compensation under the operator's service-level commitment policy.

3. SIM Card, Number Porting & KYC

Q: How long does Mobile Number Portability (MNP) take, and can it be rejected?

APPLICABLE POLICY

As per TRAI's MNP regulations, intra-circle porting must be completed within 3 working days (5 working days for inter-circle). A port request can be rejected only for specific reasons such as outstanding dues, an ongoing contractual lock-in period, or mismatched subscriber details submitted for the Unique Porting Code (UPC).

Q: My SIM got deactivated without notice. Why, and how can I get it reactivated?

APPLICABLE POLICY

SIM deactivation typically occurs due to prolonged non-usage, failed re-verification (KYC), or non-payment of dues. Operators must send prior notice before deactivation except in cases of regulatory or security directives. Reactivation requires fresh KYC (Aadhaar-based e-KYC or physical documents) at the nearest retail outlet.

Q: I lost my SIM card / phone. How do I get a duplicate SIM issued securely?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Customers must report the loss immediately to block the SIM and prevent misuse. A duplicate SIM (same number) can be issued after identity verification at a store or via the operator's app, subject to a nominal replacement fee. The old SIM is barred instantly upon issuance of the new one.

Q: Why is re-KYC being asked for my prepaid connection even though I already submitted documents earlier?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Periodic re-verification may be mandated by regulatory directives (e.g., government orders on SIM fraud prevention) or triggered by a change in usage pattern flagged by the operator's fraud-detection system. Non-compliance within the notice period can lead to temporary outgoing/incoming service suspension.

4. Plans, Recharges & Refunds

Q: I recharged with the wrong plan by mistake. Can I get a refund or plan change?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Operators generally do not offer refunds for successfully processed recharges, as per standard terms and conditions, since plan benefits are considered availed upon activation. Some operators offer a one-time plan-change/downgrade option within a short window (e.g., 24-48 hours) if benefits remain unused — subject to the specific operator's discretionary policy.

Q: My recharge amount was deducted but the plan wasn't activated.

APPLICABLE POLICY

This is treated as a failed transaction. Operators/payment gateways must auto-reverse the amount to the original payment source within a defined window (commonly 5-7 business days) if the plan is not activated. Customers can escalate with the transaction ID if the refund is delayed.

Q: Can I switch between prepaid and postpaid without changing my number?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Yes, migration between prepaid and postpaid (or vice versa) is permitted while retaining the same number, subject to clearing outstanding dues and completing a fresh service agreement/KYC. Processing typically takes a few working days.

5. Roaming & International Services

Q: Do I need to activate international roaming (IR) before traveling abroad?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Yes, international roaming is not enabled by default on most connections and must be explicitly activated (via app, USSD, or customer care), typically requiring advance activation before travel and subject to a security deposit for postpaid customers.

Q: I received unexpectedly high roaming charges. What protections exist?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Operators are required to send usage/cost alerts (e.g., at defined spend thresholds) while a customer is on international roaming to prevent bill shock. Customers can dispute charges that were incurred without such alerts being sent, in line with the operator's bill-shock protection policy.

6. Complaints, Escalation & Grievance Redressal

Q: I raised a complaint but haven't received a resolution. What is the escalation process?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Every complaint must be assigned a docket/reference number and resolved within the operator's published SLA (commonly 3-7 days depending on complaint type). If unresolved, it can be escalated to the operator's Nodal Officer, and subsequently to the Appellate Authority if still unresolved within the regulatory timeline set out in the Telecom Consumers Complaint Redressal Regulations.

Q: How do I file a complaint with the Telecom Ombudsman or TRAI directly?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Complaints to TRAI/DoT (e.g., via the TRAI DND/complaint portal or Sanchar Saathi) are generally accepted only after the customer has first approached the operator's grievance redressal mechanism and either received no resolution or is unsatisfied with it within the defined timeline.

7. Disconnection, Termination & Data Privacy

Q: How do I request permanent disconnection of my number, and will I get a refund of my balance/deposit?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Disconnection requests must be processed within a defined timeline (commonly within 24-48 hours of request for prepaid; end of billing cycle for postpaid after dues clearance). Any security deposit (postpaid) or unused prepaid balance is refundable as per the operator's refund policy, minus any applicable dues.

Q: Can my call/SMS/data records be shared with third parties without my consent?

APPLICABLE POLICY

Under telecom licensing conditions and data protection regulations, customer usage data and personal information cannot be shared with third parties without explicit consent, except when required by law

enforcement or regulatory authorities under due legal process.

Q: I keep receiving unsolicited commercial calls/SMS despite registering on the DND list.

APPLICABLE POLICY

Customers can register for the Do Not Disturb (DND) service free of charge via SMS, app, or the operator's portal. Continued unsolicited commercial communication after DND registration can be reported, and the sending entity/telemarketer is liable for penalties under TRAI's Unsolicited Commercial Communication (UCC) regulations.

Note: Policies referenced above are illustrative and based on general TRAI (Telecom Regulatory Authority of India) consumer-protection norms and common operator practice. Exact timelines, fees, and procedures may vary by operator and are subject to change; customers should confirm current terms with their service provider or refer to www.trai.gov.in for the latest regulations.